
MODULE 1

CYBERCRIME: THE PHENOMENON

Cybercrime Typologies: Cyber-enabled crimes

Barbara Vettori

Associate professor of Criminology

Università degli Studi di Napoli Federico II

Introduction to Cyber-enabled crimes

- The digital society has given a **strong boost to a number of traditional crimes** that have been enhanced by the use of computers, computer networks or other forms of information and communication technology
- In contrast to cyber-dependent crime (the topic of the last lecture), “cyber-enabled crime” (McGuire & Dowling, 2013) **can also be committed without the use of the digital world**

Cyber-enabled crime has always existed,
but now it is more **ubiquitous, faster** and more **global**

Cyber-enabled crimes: definition

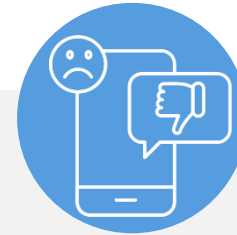
- Traditional crimes for which the Internet has opened up entirely new possibilities and opportunities
- Traditional crimes that are facilitated or have been made easier (i.e., enabled) by cyber technology (Phillips et al., 2022)
- Crimes where the computer plays a role, but that could still be committed without the involvement of the computer
- Cyber-enabled crimes range from white-collar crime to drug trafficking, to online harassment, terrorism and beyond
- **Hybrid crimes** (Wall, 2005), **computer-related** (Broadhead et al., 2018) or **people crime** (Black et al., 2019)

Cyber-enabled crimes: subcategories



Cyber-enabled crimes related to economy

- Fraud (e-commerce fraud, Mass-marketing frauds, phishing scams, pharming scams, “online romance” frauds)
- Intellectual property crimes
- Sale of illegal items on online marketplaces (also Deep o Dark Web)
- Cyber-laundering



Cyber-enabled crimes related to Interpersonal violence

- Cyber-bulling
- Cyber-mobbing
- Cyber-stalking
- Cyberharassment
- Sextortion
- Online grooming
- Trolling
- Griefing
- Assisted cyber-suicide
- Image based abuse (IBA)
- Production and dissemination of child pornography

Cyber-enabled crimes related to economy

- The world of fraud is one of the areas that has benefited most from the introduction of the internet: **The digital society has industrialized fraud!**
- Digital society is therefore particularly criminogenic in terms of fraud, so much so that one could perhaps coin the adjective “**fraudogenic**” (Button & Cross, 2017)
- Online fraud is easier to carry out and also allows for a much larger number of potential victims to be intercepted: there is a much lower risk of being detected and punished online
- Online fraud and e-commerce fraud, fraudulent sales, online mass marketing fraud, phishing fraud, pharming fraud and 'online romance' fraud (McGuire & Dowling, 2013)

Cyber-enabled crimes related to economy (I)

Different typologies (McGuire & Dowling, 2013):

- **Online frauds and e-commerce frauds**
- **Fraudulent sales** via online auction or retail sites or through bogus websites
- **Online mass marketing scams** (where individuals are tricked into paying money upfront, for example to help someone or invest in a business, with the promise that they will receive a larger sum of money back at a later date)
- **Phishing scams** (where a user tricks the victim into providing personal information, financial details or access codes by posing as a reputable entity or person in an email or other form of communication)
- **Pharming scams** (when a user is directed to a fake website, sometimes via phishing emails, to enter their personal information)
- **Online romance scams** (the victim may be contacted via social networks or dating websites and tricked into handing over personal details or money after a prolonged online 'relationship')

Cyber-enabled crimes related to economy (II)

Not only fraud:

- **Intellectual property crimes** (product piracy, counterfeiting, forgery and sale of counterfeit goods)
- **Sale of illegal items on online marketplaces** (including illegal items sold on the deep or dark web, where users can find weapons, drugs and human organs and purchase a variety of illegal services)
- **Cyber laundering** (criminals can clean the proceeds of illegal activities using cyber laundering systems: To erase the criminal origin of entire assets, some or all stages of money laundering may take place in cyberspace)

Cyber-enabled crimes related to interpersonal violence (I)

Malicious and offensive communications

- **Cyber-bullying** (intimidation and bullying of young people, less often children, through information and communication technologies, including the creation of special websites with material about the person being persecuted or by posting offensive reviews and comments)
- **Cyber-mobbing** (psychological violence in the form of bullying that uses electronic communication to insult, threaten or humiliate a victim and is usually carried out by a group of people who bully one of their group members or any user)

Cyber-enabled crimes related to interpersonal violence (II)

Online violence against other individuals

- **Cyber-stalking** (the systematic pursuit of a person, a group of people or an organization via the internet with the aim of intimidating them, blackmailing them and making demands)
- **Cyber-harassment** (a repeated psychological cyberattack through persistent insults, harassment, demands and virtual aggression. It usually manifests itself in the form of numerous messages, intrusive calls around the clock and conversations of a humiliating and insulting nature)
- **Image-based abuse (IBA)** (continuum of different forms of sexual violence that includes non-consensual intimate image (NCII) distribution, revenge porn, deepfakes or fake porn and sextortion)

Cyber-enabled crimes related to interpersonal violence (III)

Online sexual offences against children:

- **Online grooming** (form of sexual abuse of children, commercial sexual exploitation by adult users with the intention of luring underage victims)
- **Production and distribution of child pornography**

Other:

- **Trolling** (social provocation in which virtual conversation partners are involved in a controversy in order to stir up a scandal in network communication)
- **Griefing** (deliberate infliction of moral and material damage on participants in online computer games)
- **Assisted cyber suicide** (a form of psychological abuse in which the victim is driven to suicide by psychological manipulation or pressure on the internet)

Case study: E-commerce fraud

- March 2023
- 303 million euros in VAT fraud through Chinese e-commerce
- Operation “Silk Road”
- Chinese exporters evaded Belgian import taxes by declaring that consumer goods (such as electronics, toys and accessories) were destined for other EU Member States. In this way, they were exempt from Belgian VAT
- A large number of bogus companies in France, Germany, Hungary, Italy, Poland and Spain, false invoices, forged transport documents and false identities

300 million euro VAT fraud through Chinese e-commerce

Chinese 300-mln-euro 'Fraud Ring' Targeted At Belgian Airport

Chinese customs fraud ring dismantled at Belgian airport

Belgium: VAT fraud estimated at 300 million euros uncovered

Case study: money laundering

- November 2022
- Fraud with cryptocurrencies and money laundering
- Two Estonian nationals were arrested in Tallinn for their alleged involvement in a multi-layered fraud and money laundering scheme involving 575 million dollars in cryptocurrency
- They tricked victims into signing fraudulent equipment rental contracts and induced victims to invest in a virtual currency bank
- Victims paid more than \$575 million to the companies of the two defendants, who then set up shell companies to launder the fraud proceeds and buy real estate and luxury cars.

Two Estonian Citizens Arrested in \$575 Million Cryptocurrency Fraud and Money Laundering Scheme

US: 2 Estonians arrested in \$575M cryptocurrency fraud

Two Estonian Citizens Charged With Running a Series of Crypto Scams Totaling \$575M

According to the Department of Justice, the two men used shell companies to launder the proceeds of their fraudulent schemes and buy luxury cars and real estate in Estonia.

Case study: Online romantic fraud (or Romance scam)

- March 2023
- Woman was contacted on Facebook by "Larry Brooks", a self-proclaimed US Army officer stationed in Syria
- 32 victims
- The criminal group generated illegal proceeds of around €400,000 between 2018 and 2021
- Established modus operandi adapted to the need
- Italian police have arrested eight people for serious fraud, money laundering and counterfeiting

Eight arrests for "romantic" scams involving 32 women: over 400 euros stolen

"I'm Officer Brooks, I love you but I need money", the gang of "romantic scams" defeated

The victims, in love, sent their pension to the profile. In 3 years the suspects have collected 400 thousand euros

Case study: Sextortion

- March 2022
- A Nigerian man urged a 17-year-old boy to commit suicide
- The boy was contacted in March 2022 via an Instagram account that appeared to belong to a woman and had the username "dani.robertts"
- This account had been hacked and sold a 22-year-old Nigerian man who allegedly used the profile to coerce young men into sending him explicit images of themselves and then extorting money for not sharing the images

High school football player Jordan DeMay driven to suicide after Nigerian sextortion scam, anguished family reveals

Michigan teen's suicide highlights growing dangers of online sextortion plots

Nigeria hands over two suspects in sextortion case linked to suicide of Michigan high school athlete

Samuel and Samson Ogoshi are expected in U.S. federal court in Grand Rapids on Monday. Jordan DeMay died by suicide after he was tricked into sending explicit photos of himself.

Case study: Online sexual crimes against children

- **The Love Zone (TLZ):** one of the largest pedophile communities in the world (45,000 members)
- Spread pedophile practices and sell, procure or trade child pornography (CP).
- Queensland police identified the TLZ administrator in 2014, took over his account and covertly monitored the site for six months, exposing some of the forum's most active and prolific members.
- The most recent arrests date back to May and August 2023.

The Story of “The Love Zone” and “Britain’s Worst Ever Pedophile”

The takeover: how police ended up running a paedophile site

Man charged with 1623 child abuse offences allegedly linked to ‘Love Zone’ dark web paedophile network

A man charged with raping 91 young girls allegedly had material that was linked to a vile dark web paedophile network run by an Adelaide man.